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The Cultural Underpinning of Concept Creep

Frank Furedi

School of Social Policy, Sociology and Social Research, The University of Kent, Canterbury, UK

Nick Haslam's (this issue) exposition of psychology's expansive tendency to inflate harms and expand the boundaries of trauma and abuse offers a compelling account of an apparently powerful dynamic towards the reconstitution of personhood. Hitherto activities that were once perceived as ones that could be taken for granted as normal and even pleasurable have been rebranded as traumatizing and abusive. The recent trend toward the representation of the act of reading as potentially traumatizing and therefore requiring a health warning in the form trigger warnings exemplifies the cultural salience of concept creep (Furedi, 2015).

Haslam's case studies of the ascendancy of concepts of harm raise important questions about the drivers of this process. It is evident that there are a variety of cultural influences at work that intensify the sensibility of harm and the tendency to pathologize a variety of human interactions as toxic and traumatic.

As Haslam notes, psychology's concept creep is oriented toward negative harmful conditions rather than positive ones. It is our contention that this singular focus on negative concepts is not principally the outcome of factors intrinsic to developments within psychology but a reflection of wider cultural influences.

Most of the concepts of harm outlined by Haslam are not merely conditions to be suffered; they are also identity conferring. The addict, the traumatized, the bullied, the abused, and the mentally ill are not simply afflicted by their conditions—that's who they are. Many of psychology's concepts of harm communicate the conviction that these are conditions that define the victim's identity. Addicts do not transcend their condition—they become addicts in recovery.

Since the 1980s the conditions of harm discussed by Haslam have been represented as causing long-term psychological damage to the point that many victims are said to be damaged for life. What underpins the imperative of concept creep are three interrelated cultural trends: the expansion of the meaning of harm, the redefinition of personhood, and the tendency to normalize vulnerability as the defining feature of the human condition.

The Inflation of the Meaning of Harm

Perceptions of harm are underwritten by a cultural script that informs communities about its meaning. Ideas about the meaning of harm, pain, and suffering are mediated through cultural norms. In this respect, 21st-century Western societies have a uniquely low threshold for experiencing harm. As I argued elsewhere, Western societies are dominated by a culture of fear in which a growing range of every human experience has been rebranded as harmful (Furedi, 2006). At the same time, recently invented emotional harms have supplemented the numerous physical harms of everyday existence. The therapeutic sensibility that prevails in Anglo-American societies has led to a refocusing of the way harm is perceived. As a result, it is now common to represent emotional injury to the individual as more damaging than physical injury. Frequently, emotional harm is diagnosed as a lifelong sentence. Children who endure the harmful effects of trauma are described by expressions such as "scarred for life" and "damaged for life." Adults, too, are encouraged to interpret emotional injury as a harm that can damage their identity for life. Consequently, people never entirely overcome their afflictions—they are diagnosed as "in recovery."

The meaning of harm has always been subject to cultural and social variations. Practices that were once deemed harmful to the point of causing irreparable damage to body and soul—for example, masturbation—are today praised as valid ways of expressing sexual desire. Similarly, many of today's pathologies—stress, low self-esteem, indeed most forms of psychological distress—were perceived in the past as existential problems rather than as serious medical harms. From the standpoint of a sociological analysis, the diagnosis of a growing variety of psychological harms today should be interpreted as an act of social construction rather than the discovery of objective facts. This problematization of emotional life has widened the definition of harm to a historically unprecedented point.

Unlike the physical, emotional harm is limited only by the imagination. Regardless of intent, a gesture or a comment can be perceived in a way that

causes emotional harm. Virtually any parental failing can result in psychic damage. According to child protection guidelines used in Britain, emotional abuse can refer to virtually every parental failing, from “failure to meet a child’s need for affection” to being so “overprotective and possessive” that they prevent their children from experiencing “normal social contact or normal physical activity” (Furedi, 2011, p. 100–124). The expansion of the diagnosis of emotional harm is also not limited to children. In a culture where individuals are incited to regard themselves at risk, relatively routine encounters are likely to be perceived as potentially damaging to the emotion. That is why bullying, which was originally associated with childhood, has become a problem to which adults are said to be exposed. Contemporary cultural norms work to continually lower the threshold of acceptable distress and therefore encourage individuals to interpret unpleasant experiences as damaging to their health and emotions.

How people cope with painful encounters is strongly influenced by cultural and historical factors that shape the way people make sense of them. Such cultural factors may increase or reduce the ability of the individual to cope with adverse circumstances. The current tendency to problematize identity and emotion inexorably encourages people to perceive unpleasant encounters, disappointments, and slights as harmful to their psyche. Identity has been recast to the point that it is supposed that harm can be done simply by being neutral and not appearing to offer respect and recognition. Even being ignored by other people, including colleagues, is represented as a variant of emotional abuse. At the very least such experiences are held responsible for lowering people’s self-esteem, and low self-esteem is invariably presented as an invisible disease that undermines people’s ability to control their lives. The constant problematization of human emotion inexorably leads to its recycling in a disease form. Once responses to adversity are culturally validated in a disease form, they will—sooner or later—be experienced as a harmful psychological condition. Hence contemporary Western culture fuels the expansion of the range of experiences that can be labeled as harmful.

The transformation of distress into a condition of emotional injury is now reinforced by the law. People feel entitled to claim compensation for the harm they suffered for feeling offended, for loss of self-confidence or self-esteem, or for being traumatized. With the expansion of the meaning of harm, mental anguish and suffering have become legitimate claims for compensation. On both sides of the Atlantic, the harms caused by psychological distress provide the ground for awards in a growing percentage of personal injury cases. The subjective character of the harms discussed by Haslam means that they can be

attached to a variety of experiences—which in turn encourages that it too becomes captured by concept creep

Radical Redefinition of Personhood

Today’s unprecedented cultural sensitivity to the vulnerability of people to psychological harm is founded on a radically pessimistic account of the workings of human subjectivity and personhood. Current attitudes regarding the ability of people to manage emotional harm can be understood through the concept of ethnopsychology. “Every culture contains a set of ideas and beliefs about the nature of human beings, what motivates them to act, the way they perceive the world, how their minds work, and the emotions that are natural to them,” wrote Hewitt (1998, p. 138). Ideas about emotion, individual behavior, and vulnerability are underpinned by the particular account that a culture offers about personhood and the human potential. As psychiatrist Derek Summerfield (2001) contended, such cultural narratives raise questions such as

how much or what kind of adversity a person can face and still be “normal”; what is a reasonable risk; when fatalism is appropriate and when a sense of grievance is, what is acceptable behaviour at a time of crisis including how distress should be expressed, how help should be sought, and whether restitution should be made. (p. 95)

The 21st-century version of personhood communicates a narrative that continually raises doubts about people’s emotional capacity to deal with physical and emotional harms. The transformation of distress into a condition of emotional injury has as its premise the belief that people are likely to be damaged by unpleasant encounters and the setbacks thrown up by everyday life. In this context, trauma has become an all-purpose term to describe the individual’s state of mind in the aftermath of an adverse experience. As the current debate on trigger warning indicates, such an adverse experience can be as banal as being disturbed by reading about distressing events.¹

The routine portrayal of psychological damage as a long-term affliction flows from a lack of belief in the capacity of people to cope with the experience of misfortune. In contemporary culture, distress is not something to be lived but a condition that requires treatment. From this standpoint the integrity of the person is threatened through exposure to adversity. As Crain (1994) argued, this “difficulty in accepting

¹For a skeptical statement on the desirability of trigger warnings, see McNally (2014).

depression, despair and conflict—in a word disappointment—as part of life’ represents a significant ‘inhibition of the self’” (p. 158). Consequently, as Vanessa Pupavac (2001) contended that the contemporary version of personhood posits people in “the form of the pre-political frail, vulnerable victim who must be protected and enabled through therapeutic intervention” (p. 360).

The positing of people as victims of circumstances reflects Western cultural sensibilities toward the uncertainties confronting 21st-century society. These uncertainties are conveyed through the colloquial usage of the discourse of trauma, anxiety, and stress. Such an orientation sensitizes people to regard a growing range of their experiences as victimizing and as traumatizing. The expanding list of conditions coupled with the state of vulnerability mirrors a diminishing significance attached to people’s potential for resilience. “Whereas earlier psychiatry assumed the general resilience of population and sought to diagnose individual susceptibility to psychological breakdown,” argued Pupavac (2001), the current diagnosis of PTSD “assumes universal vulnerability” (p. 7). Victimizing and traumatic episodes used to be associated with unusual and often extreme events such as wars and violent crime. Today, the unusual has become the norm, and survival is perceived as more or less an everyday problem.

The Concept Creep of Vulnerability

In a world where vulnerability has become an everyday concept, it is worth noting that its colloquial usage is a relatively recent one. The ascendancy of vulnerability as the defining feature of the 21st-century version of personhood is rarely commented upon (Furedi, 2004). Yet although society still upholds the ideals of self-determination and autonomy, the values associated with them are increasingly overridden by a more dominant message that stresses the quality of human weakness.

What I have called elsewhere *therapy culture* casts serious doubts about the capacity of the self to manage new challenges and to cope with adversity. Individuals confronted with the ordinary troubles of life are now routinely advised to seek professional advice and counseling. The belief that people exist in a state of vulnerability informs the way that we are expected to make sense of our experiences. As a cultural metaphor, vulnerability is used to highlight the claim that people and their communities lack the emotional and psychological resources necessary to deal with change, make choices, and possess the emotional resources to deal with adversity. Popular culture also

encourages the view that communities and people are weak and in need of support.

The term *vulnerability* is habitually used as if it is a permanent feature of a person’s biography. It is presented and experienced as a natural state of being that shapes human response. It is a label that frequently describes entire groups in society. That is why it has become common to use the recently constructed concept of vulnerable groups. The term *vulnerable group* does not simply refer to groups of the psychologically distraught or to a small minority of economically insecure individuals. Children, indeed all children, are automatically assumed to be vulnerable. A study of the emergence of the concept of vulnerable children shows that in most published literature, the concept is treated as “a relatively self-evident concomitant of childhood which requires little formal exposition” (Frankenberg, Robinson, & Delahooke, 2000, p. 587). It is an idea taken for granted and rarely elaborated, and “children are considered vulnerable as individuals by definition, through both their physical and other perceived immaturities.” Moreover, this state of vulnerability is presented as an intrinsic attribute. It is “considered to be an *essential* property of individuals, as something which is intrinsic to children’s identities and personhoods, and which is recognisable through their beliefs and actions, or indeed through just their appearance” (Frankenberg, Robinson, & Delahooke, 2000, pp. 588–589).

However, it is not just children who are defined as vulnerable en masse, but also women, the elderly, ethnic minorities, the disabled, and the poor. Indeed, if all the groups designated as vulnerable by experts and policymakers are added together, it would appear that they constitute over 100% of the population!

Vulnerability works as a cultural metaphor rather than as a precise concept. Its meaning is far from clear and is used to describe people’s experience of a wide variety of phenomena. The promoters of this metaphor rarely ask the question, Vulnerable to what? The only answer provoked by this question is “vulnerable to everything.” So vulnerability does not exist in relation to a specific event or experience. It is a diagnosis of the human condition that perpetually encourages a sense of powerlessness and lack of agency in face of an expanding empire of harms.

The sense of vulnerability is so deeply immersed in our cultural imagination that it is easy to overlook the fact that it is a relatively recently invented concept. The term *vulnerable group* did not exist in the 1970s—it came into usage in the 1980s. One study notes that the tendency to frame children’s problems through the metaphor of vulnerability became visible in the late 80s but took off in the 1990s (Frankenberg et al., 2000, pp. 588–589).

The ascendancy of the term *vulnerability* as a distinctive cultural metaphor is paralleled by its growing usage in the social sciences. Indeed it is in the social sciences that the idea that vulnerability is a distinct attribute of individuals and of groups first acquired a distinct form. It is remarkable that the growth and expansive remit of this rhetorical idiom in the social sciences follows a pattern that is strikingly similar to its trajectory in everyday culture. The database of the *International Bibliography of the Social Sciences* between 1950 and 2004 contains 588 references to academic journal articles that contain the term *vulnerability* in the title. Of these, six were published in the 1950s, six in the 1960s, 14 in the 1970s, 45 in the 1980s, 274 in the 1990s, and 249 between the years 2000 and 2005. Although this remarkable increase in the number of vulnerability titled articles in the 1990s is to some extent a product of the expansion of journal publishing, it illustrates the growing influence of this concept in the social sciences. More important is the expansion of the usage of this term in relation to an expanding variety of groups and social experiences. It is worth noting that none of the six articles published in the 1950s used the concept of vulnerability to refer to groups or people. These articles used the term in association with the military and economic capabilities of countries and institutions. In the 1960s two of the articles linked vulnerability with the social problems facing people—juvenile delinquency. Again in the 1970s, vulnerability tended to be used as a general abstract concept and not as the characteristic of individuals and groups.

It is in the 1980s that the contemporary usage of the vulnerable as a defining feature of groups of people—the poor, elderly, mentally ill, minorities, children—is first evident. Since the 1990s the variety of experiences and types of people associated with the state of vulnerability by social scientist has steadily increased (BIDS International Bibliography of the Social Sciences, 1951–2005).

The conceptual inflation of vulnerable and vulnerability is also confirmed by research into the changing conceptualization of childhood. Until the 1970s, the social science literature tended to associate the response of children to adversity with their capacity for resilience. It was frequently argued that children were likely to respond to a disaster with resilience, especially if their family was able to serve as a source of social support. (Perry, Silber, & Black, 1956). “But about the middle of the 1970s the tone began to change as researchers began to scrutinize the matter more carefully,” noted Drabnek (1968, p. 271). The main consequences of this new focus on children’s mental health was the questioning of the power of children’s resilience and the highlighting of their vulnerability. According to Frankenberg et al. (2000), the tendency to frame children’s problems through

the metaphor of vulnerability is a relatively recent development. Their search of a major bibliographical database BIDS revealed over 800 refereed papers between 1986 and 1998 that focused on the relationship between vulnerability and children. They noted that “whilst in the first 4 years of this period there were under 10 references each year to vulnerability and children, an exponential increase to well over 150 papers a year occurred from 1990 onwards” (p. 587). They believe that this figure underestimates the tendency to interpret children’s lives through the prism of vulnerability because it ignores the substantial nonacademic literature on the subject (Frankenberg et al., 2000, p. 587).

Today, children are automatically assumed to be vulnerable. A study of the emergence of the concept of vulnerable children shows that in most published literature, the concept is treated “as a relatively self-evident concomitant of childhood which requires little formal exposition.” It is a taken-for-granted idea that is rarely elaborated and “children are considered vulnerable as individuals by definition, through both their physical and other perceived immaturities” (Frankenberg, Robinson, & Delahooke, 2000, p. 588–589). Moreover this state of vulnerability is presented as an intrinsic attribute. Vulnerability represents a statement about children’s identity. It is also a cultural tool used for endowing childhood with meaning.

Vulnerability is a concept without boundaries. The past and the present are seamlessly connected through a chain of events with a cumulative outcome of a vulnerable community. The strong claims made on behalf of the salience of the vulnerability concept give it an almost indefinable metaphysical quality. Writing of the “mental images that the concept of vulnerability evokes,” De Chesnay (2005) pointed to its free-floating transcendental quality (p. xix).

The idiom *vulnerable* should not be interpreted as merely a new word for the poor or the powerless. As a rhetorical idiom, it evokes a distinct approach toward the ideal of personhood and human agency. Previous representation of the poor highlighted the socioeconomic dimension of poverty. The poor could acquiesce, grumble, or revolt against the condition in which they lived. In contrast, vulnerability is a psychological attribute that is bound up with the very meaning of contemporary personhood. It is integral to the consciousness through which people construct their reality. As sociologist Ann Swidler (2001) observed, “people vary greatly in how much culture they apply to their lives” (p. 46). But in the very act of using culture, people “learn how to be, or become, particular kinds of persons.” Swidler claimed that such “self-forming” continually utilizes the symbolic resources provided by wider culture. In this way

people acquire a self-consciousness of what is expected of them and how they can expect to be treated (Swidler, 2001, p. 46, 71). That is why after a while, people can begin to think of themselves and others as vulnerable.

Normalization of Abuse

The conceptual expansion of the pathologies discussed by Haslam are intimately linked with the influence exercised by a narrative of personhood that is defined its dispositional vulnerability. This is a disposition that the discipline of psychology—like all the social sciences—has internalized. Conceptual creep and innovation within the field of psychology draw on the cultural resources provided by the master frame of vulnerability.

The term *master frame*, argued psychologist Michael Bamberg, “typically refers to pre-existent sociocultural forms of interpretations.”² A master frame provides an interpretative perspective of problems that resonate with the temper of the times. So the narrative of abuse discussed by Haslam draws on the master frame of vulnerability. Through the resources provided by this master frame of vulnerability narratives such as that of abuse become normalised. Such narratives can now be attached to a growing range of experiences leading to what Haslam described as their vertical and horizontal expansion.

The theme of abuse is a subject that recurs in popular culture, media reportage, and public discussion. The frequency with which the term is used, and the ever-expanding range of experiences that are characterized as abusive, indicate that it has become an important cultural resource for drawing attention to problems. Warnings about the “growing risk” of elder abuse, spouse abuse, peer abuse, or animal abuse all adopt the rhetorical strategy of universalizing the problem. Moral entrepreneurs use the rhetoric of big numbers to suggests that “we are all at risk” of abuse.

Associating new problems with already-recognized ones helps claims-makers gain attention for their cause. For example, warnings about the problem of the emotional abuse that parents allegedly inflict on their children can draw on the preexisting consensus about the harm of sexual abuse to gain public attention.

The term *abuse* is now used so widely that moral entrepreneurs often find it difficult to resist the temptation of alluding to it in their polemic. For example, in recent years opponents of male circumcision have castigated this practice as child abuse. Health activists sometimes accuse parents who allow their

overweight children to eat too much food of the same offense. Parents who educate their children to embrace the family’s religion have also been condemned as child abusers by antifaith campaigners. The vociferous proponent of atheism, Richard Dawkins (2002) expressed this sentiment when he claimed that “odious as the physical abuse of children by priests undoubtedly is, I suspect that it may do them less lasting damage than the mental abuse of having been brought up Catholic in the first place” (p. 9).

In the sociological field of the social construction of problems, a dimension of what Haslam calls concept creep is characterized as an example of *domain expansion*. Domain expansion is a tactic used to couple a specific issue to an already existing problem. For example as one sociologist explained, once “child abuse received general recognition as a social problem, various advocates began claiming that the category ought to include parental smoking, circumcision, not buckling small children into car seats, and so on” (Best, 1999, p. 170). Domain expansion occurs when child abuse provides the resources for the construction of peer-to-peer abuse, emotional abuse, and so on.

The domain expansion of abuse is paralleled by the tendency to broaden the definition of the problem. Broad definitions tend to increase the size and weight of a problem. Claims-makers working in the sphere of child protection frequently claim that society faces an epidemic of abuse. This assertion is forcefully advocated in England in the NSPCC’s report *Child Abuse and Neglect in the UK Today*. Published in 2011, the report offers a definition of maltreatment that could include virtually any unpleasant childhood experience. Maltreatment is defined as

all forms of physical and/or emotional ill-treatment, sexual abuse, neglect or negligent treatment or commercial or other exploitation, resulting in actual or potential harm to the child’s health, survival, development or dignity in the context of a relationship of responsibility, trust or power. Radford et al., 2011, p. 10)

The report defines child abuse in a way that fails to distinguish between adult predators and the acts of other children. Its definition of emotional abuse is so wide that any parenting strategy of which the NSPCC disapproves can be included in it: Emotional abuse “may include interactions that are beyond the child’s developmental capability, as well as overprotection” and “may feature age or developmentally inappropriate expectations being imposed on children” (Radford et al., 2011, p. 22). That means that parents with high expectations of their child, as well as those who are too protective of their offspring, are now diagnosed as abusers.

²Bamberg’s statement on master-frames is available at http://www.clarku.edu/~mbamberg/encyclopedia_entries.htm.

From the standpoint of rigorous social science research, the problem with broad definitions of abuse, such as those advanced by the NSPCC, is that they blur the distinction between troublesome experience, serious victimization, and the deployment of brutal physical and sexual violence. So coupling the rape and physical attack of a child with the behavior of a pushy parent has only one merit—the construction of large numbers. This methodological synthesis of a variety of otherwise disconnected childhood problems into the category of abuse is a key feature of concept creep. As sociologist Joel Best (1999) remarked, “By adopting broad definitions of victimization and arguing that victimization is both consequential and unambiguous, advocates blur distinctions among different forms of victimization” (p. 108). In this way concept creep has become a medium for constructing new problems and legitimating claims for attention and resources. With such powerful cultural drivers fueling this process, it is difficult to avoid the conclusion that concept creep is here to stay.

Note

Address correspondence to Frank Furedi, School of Social Policy, Sociology and Social Research, The University of Kent, Canterbury, CT2 7NF, UK. E-mail: frank.furedi@gmail.com

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